

Baron Nikolai Steele hunched over one of his favorite blades, the mindless repetition of the sharpening stone allowing him to sink into a deep reverie. It was always the same. Nikolai staring down waves of orcs flooding toward him in the confines of the Hot Gates, Marina and Adella both standing resolutely by his side.

But this time, She was also there, standing defiantly, unafraid, the symbol of Lathander boldly proclaiming her faith. They shared a brief glance, and he could tell they had fought together many times before.

A knock at the door pulled him from his daydream before they could spill any blood together.

“Come.”

The old mage poked his scruffy chin barely into the room and raised an eyebrow.

“I said ‘Come’, Aldric. You may enter.”

“Of course, milord. We have word from the Baroness.”

Nikolai smiled at the mention of his old friend, “And what does Adella want us to know?”

“Milord, I’m afraid I have news of death in the Telus Barony.”

“Araig is dead? Hmm, now that I think about it, I cannot remember the last time I even thought of him. Odd, that. He was always a bit arrogant for my taste, but a good steward of his people until...well, hmmm. Anyway, I suppose there will be a funeral?”

The mage looked down uncomfortably, “Erhm, no milord, the Baron is, apparently, still alive. The details are sketchy, but Lord Betony and his retinue discovered Baron Telus was under a curse of some kind and fought bravely to save him.”

“Good show!” Steele interrupted.

“Ah, yes milord, good show, indeed, but Lord Betony lost one of his top advisors in the fight. Eaten by a giant spider, it is said.”

Steele’s heart sank, his throat suddenly dry. He recalled that familiar glance they had shared in his daydream.

“The priestess? Was it her?”

“Milord?”

“Damnit, Aldric. Which of Betony’s top advisors fell in battle?! Was it the priestess of Lathander?! Lady Beatris?!”

“I’m quite sure Manfort did not say. But the Baroness Voight has called for a helpmoot. If milord wills it, the men can be ready to go with the hour. We can be there tomorrow first thing.”

“Make it so, Aldric. And send Taevyn to my chambers. He will accompany us.”

It was not until Aldric had left the room that Nikolai realized a single tear was rolling down his cheek.